

WAITING IN THE WINGS

Here are those who missed out as they have not yet completed a year in office; they'll be strong contenders in 2025

The Great Storyteller

KIRAN RAO WAITED for 14 long years to take the director seat again after her critically acclaimed debut *Dhobi Ghat* in 2010. And, it's worth the wait. *Laapataa Ladies*, her second directorial feature film, gave Netflix its biggest success in 2024 and is India's entry in the best international film category at the

Oscars 2025.

Within a month of its release on the OTT platform, *Laapataa Ladies* garnered a record 13.8 million views and held the title of the most watched non-English film on Netflix for almost three months. "Stories like these interest filmmakers like me because I feel that we need more

films on women," says a passionate Rao, who also co-produced the film. "It's exceedingly important that we invest much more in women storytellers, producers, actors, and projects helmed by women. I'll continue to want to tell stories revolving around interesting female characters," she adds.

Rao began her career as an assistant director in 2001 with Ashutosh Gowariker's *Lagaan*, which was India's official Oscars entry in 2002 for the best foreign language film. She also worked with Academy Award-nominated Director Mira Nair on *Monsoon Wedding*. Rao's directorial debut, *Dhobi Ghat*, premiered at the Toronto International Film Festival. Her accomplishments have earned her a spot on BT's Most Powerful Women in business to watch-out for list this year. Not just filmmaking, Rao co-founded non-profit Paani Foundation in 2016 to fight drought in Maharashtra.

Till now India has received just three nominations in the foreign film category at Oscars, but with no wins. With *Laapataa Ladies*, the country has its hopes up this time around. **BT**

— BY RIDDHIMA BHATNAGAR



PHOTO BY BANDEEP SINGH



SAMANTHA RUTH PRABHU, 37, Actor, Investor, and Entrepreneur

CLASS APART

Samantha Ruth Prabhu, a formidable name in Telugu and Tamil cinema, is not only known for her performances but also her foray into the investment landscape. Having bagged multiple awards, Samantha's star power extends beyond the screen. In 2020, she launched Saaki, a women's apparel brand that has swiftly carved a niche for itself. She also has stakes in brands like Nourish You and Secret Alchemist, a wellness start-up where she has recently taken on the role of Co-founder. She has also acquired the Chennai franchise of the World Pickleball League. The 37-year-old star is poised for impact, earning her a spot among BT's People to Watch out For. **BT**

— BY PALAK AGARWAL



PHOTO BY MILIND SHELTE



KIRAN RAO
50, Filmmaker, Director, and Screenwriter